STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



PEOPLE

FEEDBACK THAT CHANGES BEHAVIOUR

Why over a third of feedback made performance worse, how much of a rating is about the rater, the situation-behaviour-impact model, and a card for your next conversation.

> 1/3 of feedback interventions lowered performance instead of raising it, in a meta-analysis of 607 effects.

KLUGER & DENISI, 1996

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In this issue

Most managers give feedback every week, in a sentence at the door or in the annual review. This issue asks which feedback changes what people do, and which quietly makes things worse.

Across 607 effects, feedback raised performance on average, yet more than a third of the interventions lowered it. In two large samples of 360-degree ratings, the raters' own tendencies explained more of the ratings than the performance of the managers rated. The Center for Creative Leadership proposes describing the situation, the behaviour and its impact. And research on learning finds that feedback helps more the more information it carries.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

When feedback backfires

In 1996 Avraham Kluger and Angelo DeNisi brought together decades of studies in which people were told how they had performed: 607 effects, 23,663 observations.

607
effects from studies of feedback

0.41
average gain, in standard deviations

> 1/3
of the interventions lowered performance

The losses could not be explained by chance, by whether the feedback was positive or negative, or by the theories of the time. Kluger and DeNisi proposed that feedback works through attention: the further it moves attention away from the task and towards the self, the less it helps.

OUR READING

Feedback is not good by default. A sentence about the person pulls attention to the self; a sentence about the task keeps it on the work.

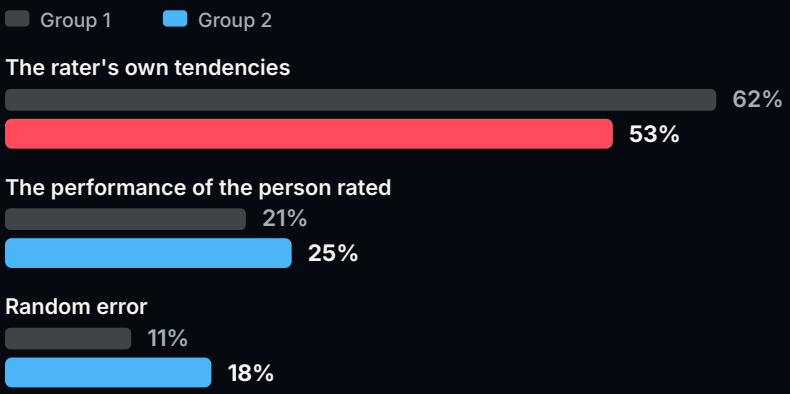
Source: Avraham N. Kluger & Angelo DeNisi, Psychological Bulletin, 1996

THE NUMBERS

What a rating measures

Steven Scullen, Michael Mount and Maynard Goff studied two groups of managers, 2,350 and 2,142, each rated by two bosses, two peers, two subordinates and themselves.

SHARE OF THE VARIANCE IN THE RATINGS EXPLAINED BY



14%
of employees strongly agree that their reviews inspire them to improve (Gallup)

≈2 million
hours a year on forms, meetings and ratings, by Deloitte's own count

OUR READING

If more of a rating is about the rater than about the person, it is a weak basis for a talk about behaviour. Behaviour both sides saw is a better one.

Sources: Steven E. Scullen, Michael K. Mount & Maynard Goff, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2000 (via Abstract at PubMed); Robert Sutton & Ben Wigert, Gallup, 2019; Marcus Buckingham & Ashley Goodall, Harvard Business Review, 2015

The ratings were 360-degree ratings for development, not for pay. The three parts do not add up to 100%.

THE MODEL

Situation, behaviour, impact

The Center for Creative Leadership teaches a simple form for feedback, situation-behaviour-impact: say when and where, what the person did, and what it caused.

01	02	03
Situation	**Behaviour**	**Impact**
When and where: the meeting, the shift, the hour.	What the person did or said, as anyone could have seen it.	What it caused for you, the team or the customer.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, AFTER A HANDOVER

Situation	At this morning's 6:00 handover
Behaviour	you read out the three open orders and who owns each
Impact	the early shift started without one call to the night lead

The same form works for what should change. The situation is invented.

OUR READING

SBI keeps feedback on what can be seen and changed. It works for praise too: precise praise tells a person what to repeat.

Source: Center for Creative Leadership, 2026

The three parts follow CCL; the example is the editors'.

More in the essay How to talk to someone who made a mistake

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Information, not verdicts

In 2020 Benedikt Wisniewski, Klaus Zierer and John Hattie pooled 435 studies with 994 effects and more than 61,000 participants. The average effect of feedback was 0.48 standard deviations.

01	**More information, more effect**	Feedback helped more the more information it contained.
02	**Rewards or punishment alone do little**	Simple rewards or punishment had low effects.
03	**Who asks for it**	In a review of 30 years of research, Frederik Anseel and colleagues found that people who seek feedback tend to want to learn, get on well with their leader and often hear positive feedback. Seeking falls with tenure, and its direct link to performance is small.

OUR READING

A verdict tells people where they stand. Information tells them what to do next. Only the second can be used on the next shift.

Sources: Benedikt Wisniewski, Klaus Zierer & John Hattie, Frontiers in Psychology, 2020; Frederik Anseel et al., Journal of Management, 2015 (via Abstract)

The 2020 participants were pupils and students, not employees; the data on seeking feedback are correlational.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Count the behaviour, not the talks

Whether feedback worked shows in what people do afterwards, not in how the conversation felt. One behaviour, counted before and after, is enough.

1. **Pick one behaviour**
   Something you can see: the checklist at handover, the call before a delay.
2. **Count it for two weeks**
   Before saying anything, so you know where it starts.
3. **Give the feedback once, with SBI**
   Then ask what would make it easier.
4. **Count again for four weeks**
   If nothing moves, change the conditions, not the speech.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, HANDOVERS WITH THE CHECKLIST

Before	4 of 10 handovers
Week 2	7 of 10
Week 4	9 of 10

The change held weeks after the conversation, which is the test. The numbers are invented.

The steps and the example are the editors'.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The feedback card

One card before a feedback conversation. Fill in the first three lines from what you saw, not from what you think of the person.

01 Situation when and where

02 Behaviour what I saw or heard, without adjectives

03 Impact what it caused, and for whom

04 My question how do you see it?

05 Next time one thing, agreed between us

06 Check the date I look at the behaviour again

Source: Center for Creative Leadership, 2026

A practice proposed by the editors; the first three lines follow CCL's situation-behaviour-impact model.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

The effects of feedback interventions on performance
Avraham N. Kluger & Angelo DeNisi, Psychological Bulletin, 1996
https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.119.2.254

Understanding the latent structure of job performance ratings
Steven E. Scullen, Michael K. Mount & Maynard Goff, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2000 · via Abstract at PubMed
https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.85.6.956

More Harm Than Good: The Truth About Performance Reviews
Robert Sutton & Ben Wigert, Gallup, 2019
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/249332/harm-good-truth-performance-reviews.aspx

Reinventing Performance Management
Marcus Buckingham & Ashley Goodall, Harvard Business Review, 2015
https://hbr.org/2015/04/reinventing-performance-management

Situation-Behavior-Impact (SBI) feedback
Center for Creative Leadership, 2026
https://www.ccl.org/articles/leading-effectively-articles/sbi-feedback-model-a-quick-win-to-improve-talent-conversations-development/

The Power of Feedback Revisited: A Meta-Analysis of Educational Feedback Research
Benedikt Wisniewski, Klaus Zierer & John Hattie, Frontiers in Psychology, 2020
https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2019.03087

How Are We Doing After 30 Years? A Meta-Analytic Review of the Antecedents and Outcomes of Feedback-Seeking Behavior
Frederik Anseel et al., Journal of Management, 2015 · via Abstract
https://doi.org/10.1177/0149206313484521

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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